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Ballot Set for California November Election After Deal Kills Disputed Tax Measure

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California voters will decide 14 statewide ballot measures on Nov. 3 after state leaders struck a last-minute compromise that removed one of the election's most contentious proposals — a measure that would have made it significantly harder for cities and counties to raise money for local services.

The agreement, reached just days before the deadline to qualify measures for the ballot, ended what had been shaping up to be a costly statewide campaign over local taxes. In exchange for withdrawing the proposed Local Taxpayer Protection Act, lawmakers approved a constitutional amendment that preserves California's long-standing two-thirds voter approval requirement for future local special taxes while avoiding broader restrictions that critics said could have limited local governments' ability to fund public safety, housing, transportation and other community services.

On June 25, California Secretary of State Shirley Weber announced that the proponents of the initiative titled "Limits Ability of Voters to Raise Revenues for Local Government Services" formally withdrew the measure before it qualified for the Nov. 3 ballot.

The proposal, backed by Jon Coupal and the Howard Jarvis Taxpayers Association, sought to tighten California's local tax rules in several ways. Among its provisions, it would have required future citizen-sponsored local special taxes to receive approval from two-thirds of voters and would have restricted certain local real estate transfer taxes adopted in recent years. Supporters argued the measure would strengthen taxpayer protections, while opponents warned it would make it more difficult for local governments to pay for essential public services.

Instead of allowing the initiative to proceed to the ballot, Gov. Gavin Newsom and legislative leaders negotiated a compromise centered on Assembly Constitutional Amendment (ACA) 22.

If approved by voters, ACA 22 would write into the California Constitution a requirement that all future local special taxes — whether placed before voters by elected officials or through citizen initiatives — receive two-thirds voter approval. Supporters said the proposal provides greater clarity and consistency in state law while avoiding broader changes contained in the withdrawn initiative.

As part of the agreement, lawmakers also removed ACA 13 from the November ballot.

ACA 13 would have required any future constitutional amendment proposed through the initiative process to pass by the same vote threshold it sought to establish. Critics called the proposal a "poison pill," arguing it was designed to discourage the Howard Jarvis-backed initiative from advancing.

State Sen. Roger Niello (R-Fair Oaks), vice chair of the Senate Budget Committee, welcomed the compromise.

A historic agreement that protects California taxpayers while preserving local government's ability to fund essential services," he said.

Niello said the agreement avoids a costly and divisive ballot campaign while restoring the two-thirds voter approval requirement for future local special taxes.

The compromise also drew praise from legislative leaders, who said it protects both taxpayer safeguards and the ability of local governments to finance essential services without years of legal uncertainty. Senate President pro Tempore Monique Limón (D-Santa Barbara) said the agreement provides voters with clear constitutional rules while

helping communities maintain reliable funding for schools, emergency response and infrastructure.

With ACA 13 officially off the November ballot, Weber announced late week that 14 other statewide measures have qualified. Five of them were referred by the Legislature and nine through the initiative process.

"Initiatives are eligible to qualify for the ballot after proponents collect and submit valid petition signatures," Weber's office said. "Initiative statutes require 546,651 valid signatures and initiative constitutional amendments require 874,641 valid signatures. The signatures are collected by the proponents and submitted to county elections officials, who verify them through either a random sample or a full signature check."

Among the legislative measures headed to voters are several proposals expected to draw broad public interest.

One of them is Assembly Constitutional Amendment (ACA) 20, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino). The measure would raise the constitutional cap on deposits into California's Budget Stabilization Account, commonly known as the rainy-day fund, from 10% to 20% of annual General Fund revenues. The proposal was certified by the Secretary of State to appear on the Nov. 3, 2026, statewide ballot as Proposition 2.

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